

7, The New Criterion I Have Adopted

My superficial research into the history of Islam concludes here. What satisfies me the most is that the entire developmental trajectory of Islam can still be perfectly encapsulated and explained within my theoretical framework, thoroughly discarding the myriad previous explanations that attributed the religion's characteristics merely to "tolerance" or "narrow-mindedness."

We now know that Islam's various manifestations across different nations and different eras were, in the final analysis, neither because Allah genuinely possessed some supreme divine power, nor because rulers possessed incomparable personal will. **Rather, they were strictly determined by the specific social stage the local region was situated in!**

A religion created by humans can ultimately never breach the natural laws governing human development. This manifests the absolute grandeur of science, while still affirming the historical significance of religion.

Beyond this, while pondering the history of Islam, because I was confronted with the predicament of information scarcity, I also attempted to actively reform my research methodology in practice. For instance, when I previously argued the thesis that Islam is a religion exceedingly suited for the early stage of **feudalization**, but fundamentally maladapted to the mid-feudalization stage and the transition to the early modern era, I adopted the **"Tri-phase Consistency"** (三相一致) principle.

The "three phases" mentioned here refer to three distinct manifestations, their importance increasing sequentially: **Phase One:** What the people of that era *said* and *thought*. **Phase Two:** What the people of that era *did*. **Phase Three:** How the society of that era *reacted*.

What I term "social reaction" refers to: in that specific era, whose speech was validated and whose was repudiated? Whose ideology expanded and whose perished? Whose enterprise succeeded and whose ultimately failed? **"Social reaction" is the holistic response made by society toward the first two phases.**

The reason I maintain that the confidence level (置信度) of these three manifestations increases sequentially is because people can easily speak falsehoods, but their *actions* will inevitably be based on their judgments of their own interests (*and the "interests" mentioned here inherently include value orientations*). Furthermore, "thought" has no choice but to be subsumed under "speech," because the reality is that no one can drill into another person's head to physically observe what they are truly thinking. If we want to comprehend another person's thoughts, they must express them—and the very act of expression introduces the possibility of fabrication!

The reason I deem the "social reaction" to be of the supreme utmost importance is because **no single individual, nor any group composed of a tiny minority, can possibly defy social being** (社会存在). Therefore, the manifestation of the societal whole possesses the absolute highest credibility!

If all three phases simultaneously point toward a single conclusion, then we can state with absolute certainty that this conclusion must be correct. If Phase Three and one other phase point toward a conclusion, while the remaining phase points in the opposite direction, we can still say that this conclusion has an overwhelmingly high probability of being correct; it is highly likely that the recorded documentation is flawed.

If the "social reaction" runs completely contrary to the directions pointed to by the first two phases, then one must still take the social reaction as the ultimate standard! Because human judgment inevitably carries the possibility of error, whereas the macro-evolution of the societal whole is inevitably predicated upon its current mode of existence.

In doing so, I have at least attempted to establish a relatively clear judgment mechanism. This is a matter of sheer necessity. While reading, I discovered far too many instances of "shooting the arrow first and painting the bullseye later" (先射箭再立靶子). In eras where historical data is as vast as the ocean, people can almost *always* cherry-pick fragments from the archives to support their own arguments. If discussions proceed this way, they will literally never end, and the correct answers might be buried forever.

Naturally, people will inevitably criticize me. After all, passing an accurate judgment on "social manifestation" is no easy feat. If one merely observes isolated social phenomena, misjudgments are not uncommon; elevating it above textual documentation might seem somewhat dangerous.

But what I want to say is this: **Everyone must adapt to the specific environment they inhabit, and my motherland is precisely such a terrifying environment!**

Although the official establishment has always flaunted China's (basically) uninterrupted Official Histories (正史文献) as a matter of immense pride, any clear-headed individual should understand: **Excessively hyping and obsessing over state-sponsored historiography is, in and of itself, a glaring symptom of a regime's severe deficit in political legitimacy!**

This is absolutely no secret. Even if we set China aside, one can easily observe the Republic of Venice. Beginning in the 16th century, Venice plunged into rapid decline. Yet it was precisely in that very 16th century that the Venetian state officially and vigorously developed historical writing, forging the "Golden Age" of Venetian historiography and the "Myth of Venice" that circulated to later generations. The reasons for this are self-evident.

If one is intimately familiar with the history of the Chinese Empire over the last millennium, one can easily comprehend just how appallingly abysmal the quality of official historiography from this period truly is! Regarding monumental historical events—such as the "Shadows of Candles and Sounds of Axes" (斧声烛影), the twelve golden medallions recalling Yue Fei (十二道金牌召回岳飞), or the Tumu Crisis (土木堡之变)—the official texts are either deeply secretive and evasive, or riddled with blatant self-contradictions everywhere. Their credibility is pitifully low.

Even domestic scholars in China conducting relevant research are forced to rely heavily on privately authored "unofficial histories" (野史) from the grassroots. Practically no one would be foolish enough to believe that the Official Histories are recounting historical facts; they are nothing more than the dynasty's imperially sanctioned fairy tales (钦定故事).

The reason I must emphasize "Tri-phase Consistency" and elevate "social reaction" to the highest echelon is inherently a forced adaptation I had to make against the exceedingly hostile informational environment I inhabit! Others might not find themselves in my environment, and thus there is naturally no need for them to unthinkingly endorse the methodologies I have adopted.

我对于伊斯兰教历史粗浅的研究也就到此为止，我认为特别让我满意的一点是伊斯兰教的整个发展历程仍然可以被框架极好地包含在内并解释，这摒弃了人们之前对于这个宗教宽容或者狭隘的各种解释。我们现在知道，伊斯兰教在不同国家和不同时期的表现归根到底不是因为真主真的有什么无上的法力，或者说统治者具有无可比拟的个人意志，而是当地所处的社会阶段所决定的。人创造的宗教，最终也不可能突破人类发展所具有的自然规律，这就在肯定宗教具有历史意义的基础上体现了科学的伟大。除此之外我在思考伊斯兰教史的时候因为面临着信息缺少的困难，也在实践中尝试改良研究方法。例如此前我在论证伊斯兰教是一种极为适合封建化早期社会的宗教，但是却难以适应封建化中期以及向近代的过渡时期这个观点时就采取了“三相一致”的原则。这里说的“三相”是指三种表现，他们的重要性依次递增，第一种表现是当时人怎么说怎么想，第二种表现是当事人怎么做，第三种表现是当时社会怎么反应。我这里所说的“社会反应”指的就是在那个时期什么人的言论得到认可，什么人的言论得到批驳，什么人的思想得以扩大，什么人的思想得以消亡，什么人的事业能够成功，什么人的事业最终失败，“社会反应”指的就是社会对于前两条所做出的回应。

之所以认为这三种表现的置信度依次上升，是因为人们嘴上可以说假话，但是行动总是会基于自己利益（这里说的利益已经包括了价值取向）的判断。而思想也不得不包括在言论里，因为事实是没有人能够进入另一个人的脑袋里去实际看到他真正在想什么，我们想要了解另一个人的思想必须由他表达出来才行，而表达就存在作伪的可能。认为社会反应是最重要的原因则是没有任何个人或者极个别人组成的团体能够对抗社会存在，因此社会整体的表现具有最高的可信度。如果这三相同时指向了一个结论，那么我们可以很肯定地说这个结论一定是对的，如果第三相和另外一相都指向一个结论，剩下一个相反，那我们也可以说这个结论有极大概率是对的，很可能是记载出了问题。如果社会反应与前两项所指向的方向相反，这个时候仍然要以社会反应为准，因为人的判断必然存在出错的可能，而社会整体的演变必然基于其当下的存在方式。

这样一来，我就至少试着建立起了一个比较清晰的判断机制，这也是没办法的事情。我在看书的时候发现先射箭再立靶子事情太多了，在历史资料浩如烟海的时期，人们几乎总是能够从资料中找到支持自己论据的部分，这样讨论是根本没个完的，正确的答案也可能被掩盖。当然人们自然免不了责难我，毕竟如何对于“社会表现”给出准确的判断并非易事，如果只观察个别社会现象出现误判并不罕见，将它凌驾于文献资料上似乎有一些危险。但是我想说的是，每个人都不得不根据自己所处环境而进行适应，我的祖国的确就是这样一个国家。虽然官方一直以中国（基本）不间断的正史文献作为一个值得夸耀的事，但是任何头脑清醒的人都应该明白，过分鼓吹和重视官修史书，本身就是政权合法性严重不足的一种表征。这一点根本就不是秘密，即使按下中国不表，人们也很容易观察到威尼斯共和国自其16世纪开始迅速衰落，然而也就是在16世纪，威尼斯共和国官方极力发展历史书写，缔造了威尼斯史学的“黄金时期”以及流传后世的“威尼斯神话”，其原因不言而喻。如果熟知中华帝国最近1000年的历史，人们就很容易理解这一时期的官修史书质量低劣到何种程度。诸如斧声烛影，十二道金牌召回岳飞，土木堡之变等等这样重大的历史事件，正史文献要么讳莫如深，要么处处自相矛盾，其可信度实在低到可怜。即使是中国国内做有关研究的学者，都不得不在研究中大量依赖于民间私撰的“野史”，几乎没人会傻到认为正史是在复述历史事实，它不过是叙述王朝的钦定故事罢了。我之所以要强调“三相一致”并且将社会反映列为最高级别，本身就是我对于自身所处的极为恶劣的资料环境不得不做出的改变，其他人未必和我处于同一环境中，因此对于我采取的手段自然不必不假思索地赞同。